Motors and speeds

Until quite recently on most lathes you adjusted the speed by moving the drive belt from one pair of step pulleys to another, and you'll still find this arrangement on the simplest and least expensive models. It is very effective and to change the speed you turn the lathe off and adjust the drive belts by hand. So on these machines, convenient access to the drive belt and pulleys is a must, as is a simple means of locking the motor platform in its new position. If you can't lock the motor in position it will bounce and this reverberates through the lathe. Fortunately most modern lathes offer Electronic Variable Speed (EVS), which enables you to adjust speed by turning a knob. You might still have a pulley arrangement too, to offer different speeds ranges and torque. A speed range of 150–2,500rpm is a good range.

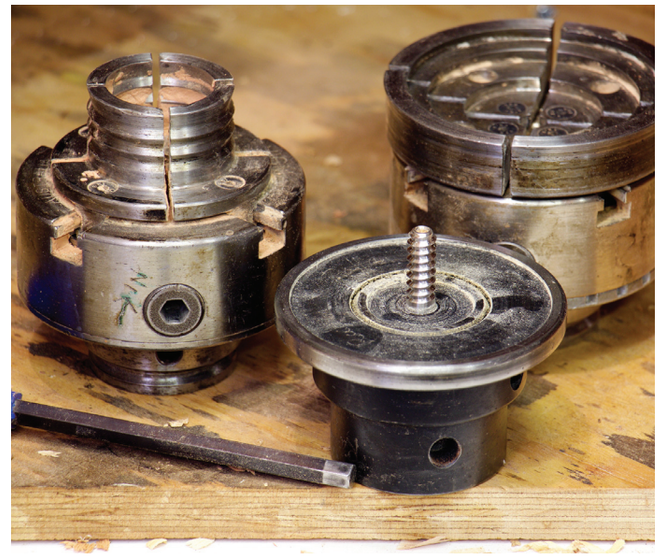
Convenient access to the drive belt and pulleys is essential on lathes without EVS

Chucks

A self-centring four-jaw woodturning chuck is now regarded as an essential lathe accessory unless you turn only spindles between centres. A chuck is typically sold with a set of jaws, with others available as extras. A chuck is bought either directly threaded or with an insert to fit your lathe's drive shaft.

The chuck I use has jaw rims that enable me to grip jobs without marking the wood. A good screw chuck is a must too. Many chucks have screw thread accessories – some are excellent and others not so good. You might find that a dedicated screw chuck might be superior to any screw accessory supplied with a standard chuck. I use Shark Jaws (shown on the left of this photo) for endgrain work like boxes, spinning tops or drawer knobs, and my Step Jaws (shown on the right of the photo) make turning bowls a lot easier.

Everyone works slightly differently and there are many good chucks available: Oneway, Record Power, Robert Sorby, Nova, Axminster and no doubt more. Ask fellow turners or club members and do your research. Each chuck manufacturer has different jaws designs. With most brands you cannot cross fit jaws from other makes, but there are a few where this is possible, which helps you to pick and mix.



I use these Vicmarc chucks all the time

Turning tools

First up: NEVER purchase a very cheap set of turning tools unless you particularly want the box they come in: even those claiming to be High Speed Steel (HSS) never hold an edge for more than a few seconds. Likewise, if you hope to cut wood cleanly, avoid cheap sets of scrapers with replaceable tips claiming to make turning easy – although if you enjoy hours of sanding, they could be just what you want. Having said that, there are some scrapers with replaceable tips and some which are able to swivel or have shanks that are articulated that are very helpful and work well.

Most novice turners purchase tools they will never use, so unless you're a serious tool junky, purchase tools as you need them. A basic set of tools is all you need to turn almost anything. In the photo above right, to the left are tools for facework like bowls and platters; to the right are tools for spindles and endgrain work like boxes and goblets. In the centre is a 13mm spindle gouge, the tool to have if you can only afford one. To the left of that is a 9mm spindle gouge, my preferred tool for cutting beads, coves and finials on both face- and centrework. Next left are 9mm and 13mm bowl gouges, then a bowl scraper. To the right of the spindle gouges are a 19mm skew chisel, a parting tool, a 19mm square-end scraper and 19mm round-nose scraper for hollowing endgrain but also useful for facework. Names to look for are Sorby, Henry Taylor, Hamlet, D-Way, Crown handtools, Thompson and P&N. There are more, but check with friends to see what they are using too. Buy good quality tools and you only buy once, not twice.

You can turn almost anything with just a basic set of tools

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